I next turn to the Italian merchant and explorer, Marco Polo, and his social portrait of the Coromandel Coast. Returning home to Venice from China in 1292 CE, Marco spent a few weeks or months in the kingdom of the Tamil Pandyas near modern Thanjavur, before sailing up the Malabar Coast. He noted that people eat with only their right hand and keep the left for 'unclean' tasks, avoid putting their lips on drinking flasks and consider darker skin more attractive. After Marco, additional portraits of the Malabar Coast came from Ibn Battuta of Morocco, Abdur Razzaq of Persia, Afanasy Nikitin of Russia and others, who also describe striking family norms that have gone extinct along with many social habits and prejudices that survive today.

I then visit the breathtaking ruins of Vijayanagar in Hampi, Karnataka. Once the capital city of the Vijayanagar Empire (c. 1336–1565), it was famed for its wealth, military prowess and cosmopolitanism. How did it acquire all the riches that foreign travellers gushed about? Was Vijayanagar a self-conscious bastion of Hinduism heroically resisting Islam for centuries, as Hindu nationalists claim? What is its legacy in south India? For such questions and a sense of its rulers, economy, trade, social customs and festivals, I lean on both scholars and visitors like Razzaq, Niccolo de Conti of Italy, and Duarte Barbosa, Domingo Paes and Fernao Nuniz of Portugal. Near Hampi, I also meet Krishna Devaraya, eighteen generations apart from his famous namesake and royal ancestor.

I then turn to François Bernier, a French physician who spent twelve years in north India (1658–69), mostly working for a nobleman in Aurangzeb's court. A rationalist steeped in the mindset of the emerging Enlightenment in Europe, he wrote about the pomp and the glitter of the Mughal court, as well as the fine architecture of Delhi and Agra. Eager to explain the recently discovered principles of blood circulation, he was known to cut open living goats and sheep before his horrified hosts in Delhi. His insightful analysis of the causes of the dismal social and economic conditions of ordinary Indians in pre-colonial India also reveals how woefully unprepared Indians were for the cultural and economic onslaught of European imperialism.

Finally, I visit Varanasi, a city inhabited since antiquity. Archaeological remains of its lost worlds, including ancient Kashi and Sarnath, date to early first millennium BCE. Steeped in religious mythology, Varanasi has